

Alex the Locksmith

How I Escaped a Scam, Learned the Trade, and Built a Real Business

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Note to the reader

This is the **v0 manuscript draft** based on a first interview. A few dates, names, and links are intentionally left as placeholders until we confirm them.

If you've ever been locked out, overcharged, or felt powerless in a stressful moment—this book is for you.

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1. The Ad That Changed Everything

I started at rock bottom.

Not in the dramatic movie way—more like the quiet kind of rock bottom where you're job hunting, you're broke, and you realize you don't even trust your own plan anymore.

I barely knew tools.

I'd never used a drill. I could barely use a screwdriver. I wasn't the "handy guy." I wasn't the "blue collar since birth" guy. I was just a guy trying to get a foothold.

And then I answered a locksmith ad.

At the time, it sounded simple: help people, unlock stuff, get paid, learn a trade.

That ad didn't just change my career. It changed how I look at people under pressure.

2. The Scam I Didn't See Coming

I didn't know it on day one, but I had stepped into a nationwide locksmith scam.

Foreigners posing as locksmiths. Flooding Google with ads and fake pages. Dispatching whoever they could to show up fast, drill first, and charge as much as possible.

The whole thing is built around one ugly truth:

When you're locked out, you're not shopping. You're panicking.

And panic makes people easy to manipulate.

I was thrown into the fire.

At first I didn't understand the playbook. I was just trying to do the job. But the longer I stayed, the more patterns I saw.

- They didn't care about skill.
 - They cared about speed.
 - They cared about maximizing the ticket.
 - And if something went wrong... you were on your own.
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3. Baptism by Fire

Locksmithing is one of those trades where you can't fake competence for long.

You either solve the problem... or you don't.

And unlike a lot of jobs, the customer is right there watching.

Not just watching—**needing**.

A lot of my early learning wasn't gentle.

It was:

- “Here’s the call. Go.”
- “Figure it out.”
- “Don’t make us look bad.”

The scam company’s “training” wasn’t training.

It was conditioning.

I learned the difference later, when I got serious about the craft:

| A real locksmith tries to pick first and drill last.

In the scam world, it was the opposite.

| “We don’t pay you to pick locks... we pay you to drill and charge as much as possible.”

That line stuck with me—because it told me everything about who they were.

4. Mt. Dora at 2AM

There’s a job that’s burned into my memory because it taught me what this business can do to you.

It was around 2AM in Mt. Dora.

A homeowner was locked out. They were the rightful homeowner. I handled it the way I knew how at the time—I drilled and replaced the lock.

Then the neighbors called the cops.

I finished up and left.

As I’m driving, I look up and see a helicopter and multiple police cars. My first thought was:

“Somebody’s in trouble.”

Then I got pulled over.

Here’s the part people don’t expect:

The cops were cool.

They saw my business card. They saw the shirt I made. They understood.

But I was freaked out anyway.

Because I realized something I'd never really sat with before:

If they weren't cool, I could've been detained.

And the scam company?

They didn't answer.

No backup. No "we'll handle it." No support.

Just silence.

That night was the moment I stopped pretending the scam world was normal.

5. Left Out to Dry

I felt left out to dry.

That's the only way to describe it.

The company that sent me there didn't care that I could've been arrested. They didn't care that I was alone at night, dealing with police, trying to explain what I was doing.

They cared about the transaction.

Not the people.

That's the exact opposite of how locksmithing should work.

So I started planning my exit.

Not with some dramatic "I quit today" speech.

With what I knew.

I've made shirts for years.

So I started making my own locksmith T-shirts and uniforms.

It sounds small, but it mattered.

A uniform is identity.

It's also credibility.

And for me, it was the first brick in building something real.

6. Winter Park Roadside

Eventually I quit.

And I started my own thing: **Winter Park Roadside**.

At first it was simple: emergency lockouts.

I was eager to learn.

I was done being someone else's disposable technician.

I wanted to be a locksmith.

A real one.

There's a marketing lesson I learned that I still believe:

| Naming your company after a city gives you an all-time buff.

I think in RPG terms sometimes.

"Winter Park" was more than marketing.

I graduated from Winter Park High School.

It's personal.

The first logo/mascot was tied to that identity (tiger / wildcat — **placeholder: confirm**).

And I made my early uniforms myself.

Those first days were scrappy, but they were mine.

7. Being Superman for Five Minutes

There's a reason I love this work.

It's the moment you solve the problem.

The moment someone goes from panic to relief.

I call it:

| Being Superman for five minutes.

A locksmith shows up when somebody's day is falling apart.

- A mother locked out at night with her kid.
- A tired paramedic who just wants to get back in the truck.
- Someone escaping domestic violence.
- Someone dealing with dementia.

Those are real moments.

And if you're the kind of person who can stay calm and treat people right in those moments—this job can make you proud.

My rule is simple:

Treat customers like you'd treat your own family.

Like your mom.

Like your grandma.

8. The Work That Actually Pays

People think locksmiths only open cars.

That's what the public sees.

But the real business is broader.

Here are my top services by revenue/frequency (from my experience so far):

1. **Safe lockouts**
2. **House rekeys**
3. **Commercial hardware installs**
4. **House lockouts**
5. **Car lockouts**

That list surprises people.

Safe work especially.

(Placeholder for batch 2: what types of safes + most common failure modes.)

9. The 1% of Customers

Most people are good.

Most people are just stressed.

But there's a tiny slice—maybe 1%—that will test you.

- The overly paranoid customer who keeps calling you back for “safe issues” that are really user error.
- The ego-tripping guy mad for no reason.

Early on, I had moments where customers tried to bully me.

One time a customer got mad about the price and went to get a bigger “homie”—a guy who towered over me.

I stood firm.

Because here's the thing:

My car wasn't locked.

I could leave.

And I told him that.

That wasn't about being tough.

That was about boundaries.

And it was empowering.

10. The Rules I Won't Break

I'm a flat-fee, upfront-pricing person.

No surprises.

No “we'll see when we get there.”

I also have ethics.

- Golden Rule: treat customers like family.
- Veterans get discounts—sometimes free services.
- Always try non-destructive entry: **pick first**, drill last.

If you want the shortest possible summary of my business:

I'm building the locksmith company I wish showed up when I was learning.

11. The Pop-A-Lock Myth

A lot of people think locksmiths only open cars.

They'll call you the "pop-a-lock man."

And honestly, I get why.

Brands can get a stranglehold on the public's vocabulary.

Pop-A-Lock is so well known it becomes the default label—like how people call cotton swabs "Q-tips."

But locksmithing is bigger than cars.

Some locksmiths work on:

- prisons
- safes
- high-end commercial systems
- specialty hardware
- even security cameras and access control

And that's why I care about education.

Because when customers understand the trade, they get scammed less.

12. A Quick Home Security Audit

Most people think security is one big thing.

It isn't.

It's layers.

Here's a simple "multiple levels of security" checklist you can walk through:

1. Doors

- Reinforce strike plates (long screws into studs)

- Check deadbolt quality and alignment
- Consider upgrading to Grade 1/2 hardware where it matters

2. Sliding glass doors

- Add a secondary bar/rod
- Check the latch and track
- Add simple sensors if you want alerts

3. Windows

- Verify locks work
- Add pin locks for sliding windows

4. Lighting

- Motion lights outside entry points

5. Visibility

- Trim bushes near windows/doors
- Keep hiding spots minimal

6. Habits

- Don't broadcast travel plans publicly
- Don't hide keys in obvious places

(**Placeholder:** link to Alex's pinned sliding-glass-door video.)

13. What's Next

This book is part story and part warning.

Because I've seen the scam side.

I've seen what happens when people are stressed and vulnerable.

And I've seen what happens when a real locksmith shows up and treats them right.

If you're a customer: you deserve upfront pricing, respect, and options.

If you're a locksmith: you deserve to learn the craft the right way—without being trained to screw people.

And if you're building a business:

Don't build it on panic.

Build it on trust.

Batch 2 questions (to finalize v1)

1. Confirm timeline: what year did you start, and when did Winter Park Roadside launch?
2. Tiger vs wildcat mascot?
3. Safe lockouts details: types + common failure modes.
4. Pinned video link + social handles to include.
5. Any specific scam call scripts/pricing tactics you want to expose (high level, not instructional).